The Redmond Tech Orchestra presents

SYMPHONIC FANTASIA

Paul Dukas	La Péri – Fanfare	3′
	The Sorcerer's Apprentice	11′
Igor Stravinsky	Firebird Suite (Selections, 1919 & 1910 ed.)	10′
Ottorino Respighi	Pines of Rome (Selections, mvt. I, III, IV)	11′
	— Intermission —	
Ludwig van Beethoven	Symphony No. 5 in C minor, Op. 67	35′

La Péri – Fanfare

Paul Dukas spent his entire life in Paris, where he was revered as a teacher, critic, and composer — though he was so self-critical that he destroyed most of his own works before his death. A close friend of Claude Debussy from their student days at the Paris Conservatory, Dukas later mentored a generation of French composers including Olivier Messiaen. In 1912, Dukas composed this brilliant brass fanfare as a prelude for his ballet La Péri, his only completed ballet and the last work he allowed to be published. The ballet tells the story of Iskender (Alexander the Great), who embarks on a journey to find a flower that grants immortality. He discovers it in the hands of a sleeping Péri — a female genie from Persian mythology — who awakens and seduces him to reclaim her treasure before ascending to the heavens. Listen for the regal opening in D-flat major, where horns and trumpets in striking major triads announce Iskender's royal entrance. Halfway through, the music shifts to capture the Péri — mysterious, ethereal, and unsettling — through flowing major seventh chords, triplets, and inversions that drift like smoke in the air before the fanfare returns to its majestic home key.

The Sorcerer's Apprentice

Dukas's enduring masterpiece from 1897 is based on *Der Zauberlehrling*, a poem by Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, and was immortalized by Disney's *Fantasia* (1940) with Mickey Mouse as the hapless apprentice. The story is irresistible: left alone in his master's workshop, a young apprentice uses a half-learned spell to animate a broomstick into fetching water. The broom obeys — but the apprentice cannot remember how to stop it. As the water rises, the desperate boy chops the broom in half, only to watch in horror as both halves continue the task at double speed. The sorcerer returns just in time to utter the magic words and restore order.

Dukas follows Goethe's narrative stanza by stanza through his orchestration. Listen for the soft, mysterious strings that conjure the sorcerer's workshop at the opening. The bassoon introduces the unforgettable broom theme, while muted brass intone the magic spell. As the chaos builds, the full orchestra churns with rising waters and the apprentice's frantic pleas. After the boy splits the broom, the contrabassoon takes up the marching theme — now doubled. At the climax, the brass thunders the spell theme as the sorcerer returns, and calm is restored. Four sharp chords at the end suggest the master has delivered a few swift disciplinary strokes to his wayward student.

Firebird Suite (Selections, 1919 & 1910 ed.)

Igor Stravinsky's *The Firebird* (1910) launched the young Russian composer to international fame virtually overnight. Written for Sergei Diaghilev's Ballets Russes, this enchanted fairy tale follows Prince Ivan, who captures the magical Firebird and receives a glowing feather in exchange for her freedom — a token that will later save his life. Today's performance will include the following four of the seven selections from the 1919 suite, with some of the 1910 original orchestration included.

Princesses' Khorovod

Prince Ivan watches as thirteen princesses, held captive by the evil sorcerer Kastchei, perform a gentle round dance (khorovod) in the moonlit garden. A lilting clarinet introduces the Princess of Unearthly Beauty, and Ivan soon reveals himself with a noble horn solo. The princesses invite him to join their circle dance, set to an oboe melody drawn from a Russian folk tune. Listen for the delicate interplay between woodwinds and strings as the dance unfolds with graceful, almost dream-like calm.

Infernal Dance

When Ivan is captured by Kastchei's monstrous followers, he waves the Firebird's feather, summoning her to cast a spell that compels the creatures into a savage, uncontrollable dance. The music erupts with brutal, driving rhythms and simultaneous layers of different meters that create a disorienting frenzy. Listen for the massive dynamics marked *fff* that push the orchestra to its limits.

Berceuse

The Firebird's lullaby gently subdues the exhausted dancers, charming them into a deep sleep. A lazy, lyrical theme unfolds in the bassoon while the descending four-note Firebird motif hovers above like a fading spell. This ravishing movement suspends time itself, its serene melody coaxing even the fearsome Kastchei into slumber, allowing Ivan to discover and destroy the giant egg that holds the sorcerer's immortal soul.

Finale

A solo horn intones the score's most famous folk tune, heralding the joyful arrival of sunlight. The rescued captives and their freed lovers celebrate as this simple theme is gradually developed into a majestic hymn of thanksgiving. The music swells through the full orchestra, brass ringing out in glorious triumph as love and light overcome darkness — the very essence of the fairy-tale ending.

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Pines of Rome (Selections, mvt. I, III, IV)

Ottorino Respighi's *Pines of Rome* (1924) is the second of his Roman trilogy of tone poems, each painting vivid scenes of the Eternal City. Respighi himself described the work as using 'nature as a point of departure' to recall 'sentiments and visions.' The orchestra will perform three of the four movements:

I: Pines of the Villa Borghese

Children are at play in the pine groves, dancing, mimicking marching soldiers, and twittering like swallows at evening. Listen as the opening fanfare bursts forth in horns and cellos, with swirling upper strings and flutes announcing the festive scene. The initial fanfare is tossed from oboe to clarinet to brass, while pizzicato strings create a sense of skipping and jumping. Horns and trumpets trade playful jests as the excitement builds to a cacophonous peak — then cuts off abruptly, as though the children have suddenly been called home.

III: Pines of the Janiculum

A moonlit night on the Janiculum Hill. The atmosphere shifts immediately to one of quiet yearning, as the clarinet sings in long, arching phrases. As the movement fades, a magical moment emerges: the distant call of a nightingale, not from the orchestra but from a phonograph, its recorded song floating above the clarinet's final notes while harp and strings draw the music to a hushed close. In choosing this real birdcall, Respighi became the first composer to weave a phonograph recording directly into an orchestral score.

IV: Pines of the Appian Way

A relentless marching rhythm emerges in the low strings and piano, faint at first, representing the distant approach of a Roman army along the ancient road at misty dawn. The clarinets quietly introduce what will become the movement's great fanfare. Gradually the volume and intensity grow — the rhythm of unending steps — until the brass unleash a heroic proclamation, passed around the section with mounting grandeur. The movement marches to a triumphant, blazing conclusion, as if an entire Roman legion has materialized before our eyes, cresting the Capitoline Hill in the light of a newly risen sun.

Symphony No. 5

Ludwig van Beethoven's Fifth Symphony (1808) is perhaps the most iconic work in the entire symphonic repertoire. Its famous four-note opening, symbolizing fate knocking on death's door — short-short-short-LONG — is the seed from which an entire musical drama grows, tracing a journey from stormy struggle to radiant triumph. As Beethoven himself wrote: 'Joy follows sorrow, sunshine — rain.'

First movement

The opening gesture is one of the most famous beginnings in all of classical music. Those four hammered notes establish the stormy temper of the Allegro and serve as a rhythmic cell that permeates nearly every measure of the movement. Listen for the gentler second theme, announced by a horn call, which offers only a brief respite — underneath it, cellos and basses quietly persist with the original motif. The development section is a paragon of logic and concision. Before the recapitulation,

listen for a breathtaking series of hushed chords passed between woodwinds and strings, building up to the roaring return of the main theme. Stark hammer-blows bring the movement to its powerful close.

Second movement
A lyrical contrast to the intensity of the opening. Two contrasting themes form the basis of a set of variations: the first is a sweet, singing melody presented by violas and cellos over pizzicato basses; the second begins softly in clarinets and bassoons before suddenly blazing forth as a heroic fanfare with trumpets and timpani — instruments rarely heard in slow movements of this era. The ensuing variations alternate between these gentle and majestic characters, with striking dynamic contrasts and a closing crescendo that leads to a quiet, resolute cadence.

Third movement
The Scherzo brings the famous four-note rhythmic motto roaring back, now led by brazen horns. In the central trio section, cellos and basses launch a scurrying passage that is taken up by other instruments in a playful, informal fugue. But the real surprise comes when the Scherzo returns: instead of a full-volume reprise, Beethoven hushes the orchestra to plucked strings and soft woodwinds, creating an atmosphere that is mysterious, hushed, and faintly ominous. Rather than ending, the music wanes to little more than a heartbeat from the timpani, then gradually accumulates intensity — building and building — until it erupts directly into the finale without pause.

Fourth movement
Brilliant sunlight bursts through ominous clouds. The finale arrives in the triumphant key of C major, and Beethoven's expansion of the orchestra's sonic palette to include: the piccolo, three trombones, and contrabassoon; instruments that are now included in the modern orchestra as he composed for the start of the transition from classical to romantic era. The movement overflows with bright, optimistic themes, and the development cleverly revisits the hushed mystery of the Scherzo — a fleeting backward glance before the triumph sweeps it away. Listen for the monumentally extended coda: again and again the music seems ready to end, only to gather speed and energy for yet another jubilant cadence. It is as though Beethoven cannot stop celebrating the victory of light over darkness.

Program notes by Sabrina Ang

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Italics denote principals
Asterisks (*) denote instrument doubling

Our Mascot

Moomie's musical journey began on the farms of Carnation, WA, when she started learning cowbell at just three months old. Her musical talents brought her to the Redmond Tech Orchestra where she happily spends her days enjoying soft classical music, munching on organic grass and grains, and being loved by the members of the orchestra.

In her spare time, Moomie loves to explore the Puget Sound and to find new friends to share her love of music. Her all-time favorite composers are Brahms and Ravel, and she loves Saint-Saëns' *Carnival of the Animals*, which has so many references to her animal friends! Moomie's excited to meet you all and see you at our future concerts.

Fun fact: Moomie weighs 10.2 pounds!

Upcoming Concerts

Join us in July at the Redmond Performing Arts Center for our Shakespeare themed concert featuring works based off the stories of *A Midsummer Night's Dream, Romeo & Juliet*, and more!

July 16, 2026, 7:00pm
July 18, 2026, 4:00pm

Support the Orchestra

As a nonprofit organization, the Redmond Tech Orchestra relies on your generous donations to continue bringing music to the community. Your support helps us organize events and foster a love for music in the greater Redmond area. Please consider donating to help us keep the music alive. Every contribution, no matter the size, makes a significant impact.

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